

Red panda

Ailurus fulgens

Once thought to be related to giant pandas, the red panda has closer genetic links to weasels and raccoons. Also called the firefox in China, this slow-moving mammal spends most of its life in trees in Asia's mountain forests, where its striking reddish brown fur allows it to blend in with the moss-covered branches of its arboreal home.

Red pandas move slowly to conserve energy as the bamboo shoots and leaves that make up most of their diet are so indigestible. They eat up to 30 percent of

their body weight daily, but use only about a quarter of bamboo's available nutrients; yet, they rely on the plant to survive when other food is scarce. In winter, red pandas can lose up to 15 percent of their body weight due to lack of food, so they slow down their metabolism to compensate as temperatures fall.

Red pandas mate on the ground, but females return to their nest to give birth to between one and four cubs, which stay with their mother for a year or more.



- ↔ 20–29 in (51–73 cm)
- ⚖ 7–13 lb (3–6 kg)
- ⊗ Vulnerable
- 🍵 Bamboo, fruit, insects, eggs
- 🏠



S. to SE. Asia

◁ WATCHFUL GAZE

Although they regularly use scent marking, red pandas also communicate with each other using “stare downs” accompanied by head bobbing and vocalizations.



△ MOVING A CUB

Female red pandas move their cubs to different nests to avoid discovery by predators such as martens and snow leopards.

red-and-white markings provide camouflage

